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Josephine Davies

Saxophonist and composer Josephine Davies is stretching the boundaries of jazz in the U.K. Her trio, Satori, gives life to her inventive compositions, and is a platform for her saxophone explorations. In 2019 she was honored with the Parliamentary Award for Jazz Instrumentalist of the Year.

Josephine was interviewed via Zoom on October 14, 2025 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive in Central New York, and I'm pleased to be talking with Josephine Davies in England. Welcome.

JD: Thank you, Monk. It's great to be here.

MR: I see you in a studio setting and I saw a quote from you I'll start with and I'll just paraphrase but you were talking about writing tunes and inspiration and that you depend often on your bandmates to make new ideas recordable. And I thought that was an interesting adjective, and what for you makes (now that you're in the studio recording) what makes a tune or a composition worthy of recording?

JD: Ah. I don't remember saying that. But I think there were lots of different directions I could go in and I was probably – I would probably answer that differently depending on which project I'm recording. So Satori is my trio, drums, bass, and me. And for that one I would say less is very much more, so I try to write very simple motific themes that we can then develop as a band. So there's lots of freedom, lots of space. It can go anywhere. So in that sense I'd probably say I won't want to make something recordable but that we'll just see what happens in the session. Whereas if the project is either -- the last album I did was with the great English piano player Alcyona Mick. So the tunes that I wrote for that were much more involved, much more harmonically dense, much more complex I suppose. And then I would really want to have a sense of more of the structure in the shape of how it would end up. And I suppose what I meant by that quote might have been more we need to play it in, we need to gig these kind of tunes before we record them so that we're comfortable with where we could go. Otherwise it's a bit – you get in that recording mindset of, "Well that wasn't really the take, let's do it again, and then you're trying to find something rather than allow all this spontaneousness, spontaneity let's say, that comes out of those situations.

MR: That's a great explanation. And when you said "less is more" it just made an impression on me because over my shoulder is the picture of Count Basie, who that was his mantra for a lot of things, you know with his own playing and the arrangements that he liked, he didn't want them to be too dense. So you're after spontaneity with this particular project.

And do you have a sense of – you do a take and everybody in the trio says, "That's it. We don't need to do that one again."?

JD: Yeah. That's the best case scenario. And I suppose because for me the studio situation is always a challenge because I get so much out of the live playing situation and I really feed off the audience and I love the sense of connection with the bands and the audience and the space and the venue and that way of well this is only happening in this moment, that's it. You're never going to hear it again. And actually two of my albums are live albums and they are, I think, arguably the better albums. Who knows? There are good things and bad things because you can't polish it after it's happened. So in a studio situation yeah, I'd say that the best case scenario is when you feel like you've done a take, that was it. We've got nothing more to say, you don't need to say anything more, it was tight enough, although that's not my main requirement. The main requirement to me is that everyone says something authentic and there's something happening and it's lively and it's interesting. And then the bits that don't quite sound as polished as they could be, for me I can let go of that rather than have a very perfect take that's perhaps not that interesting. Because there's so much music in the world. You know there's so much of deep interest that what I'm looking for, what matters so much to me is something different, something alive, something where you can really hear the personality of the musicians. And then to me it doesn't matter if there's a bit that's, you know, the hit between the bass and the drums doesn't quite happen at the same time while someone plays a fluffed note. And those things are less important to me.

MR: I'm going to guess that perhaps you do not take advantage of the technology that enables us now to get rid of a stray note. Or, "Oh the bass hit this just before the bass drum, let's move the note."

JD: I would say that's a very fair comment. Yes. I don't necessarily take advantage of all the technology. In some ways maybe I could do more of that but in other ways I think whatever happens on the day happens on the day and that's what people get. I always think that we as musicians are so overcritical of what happens, our own playing primarily, and we can get really caught up in knots that that could have been better. And the technology allows us to make changes that we wouldn't otherwise be able to. And there's something about that, that I can never make a definitive statement of what's right and wrong with the different – and different genres of music will require different technological input. And, but I guess there's always a question mark for me around how much are we going to edit a jazz performance? Is that what John Coltrane would have done?

MR: Yeah, we'll talk more about him in a bit. The idea of your audience – I was curious about this. If you think about for many years an audience would go to a club and they would

hear often times standards and things they knew. So does your audience respond or behave differently than if they went to a club and someone was playing "All the Things You Are" and we hear, you know, a little applause after everybody's solo. I'm imagining that your setting is somewhat different than that.

JD: It can be. Yes. I would say, I mean I do a lot of varied work. My favorite kind of concert is really almost a chamber music concert you know, where people are really turning out to listen and there's an atmosphere and there's a sort of responsiveness – that kind of setting. And a lot of the time in that sort of setting I get audience members coming up to me at the end saying, "I was really moved" which makes me so happy because I think that's such a gift to be able to give something to the world which is going to emotionally connect with strangers. I think that's just incredible. And that's what I want when I go to see any kind of performance in any of the arts. I want to be changed as a person. And however, it's not only that. When I go – maybe I'll go and see something that perhaps is more in the jazz tradition where you can hear such atmosphere in the audience that maybe it is a little bit more, "Well I'm going to applaud this person's solo because it was fantastic" and it's more in that tradition of each person in the band is doing something quite outrageously good and the audience is involved on that level. My example I suppose, funny enough I was listening to this yesterday because I'm taking down one of the tunes on this album which is "Spirit of the Moment" which is Joshua Redman's album – live album at the Vanguard – maybe it's – I think it's the Vanguard. And the audience are just incredible, you know whooping and hollering. And he plays this blues lick on something or other, and they just go nuts for it you know because he's a real showman, much more so than perhaps I am, and of course it's just an astonishingly good saxophonist, so he's really got the audience on his side. And I love that as well. So it's not always that I want that sort of more chamber music environment. But that's certainly where I perhaps feel most at home so that the band and I can really develop something, open something up. And that sort of music perhaps is more free, is more of the originals and stuff that I do rather than the standards gigs or things like that. So I guess there are two different areas that I really like to play in, and they're quite different but perhaps it's all about just being authentic in the moment.

MR: Do you feel it's helpful to – I'll use the word "explain" -- if you introduce one of your original compositions do you want to give the audience some backstory to it? Maybe where the title came from or just the intent? Or do you just let them explore that themselves?

JD: That's a really good question, and I'm always in two minds about it. Because obviously music is – well instrumental music this is obviously wordless stories let's say. So there is something about allowing the audience to have their own experience of it and make their

own narrative. But I do think sometimes they like to know a bit about where the music has come from. And often I do have an influence, sometimes quite a specific influence. But then I think well how visible is that in the music? For example we just recorded – before I sat down for this interview – a new piece of mine called "Unwritten" and it's inspired by the female lineage and all the stories that have not been written because the women in my lineage have not been able to – for whatever reason – been able to write their stories. There've been too many children or too much commitments, too many other things that they have to do in life. Or maybe they tried to and their stories got lost or they weren't able to publish. Things like that. And now I'm in this position of being able to be able to write – not words but music – and get that out into the world. And there's that really tangible difference between me and say my grandmother. So this piece of music is very much an homage to the female lineage. So sometimes I say that story before we start. And the first bit of the piece is this sort of floaty kind of -- hopefully a beautiful little melody. But sometimes I think ah – I'm not really feeling the need or the pull towards saying all of that before we start the piece so sometimes I don't say anything. And I don't think there's one right way of doing it. Some people say loads about a piece before they play it. And then you think well that's not what I was imagining as you were telling me this long narrative of a walk along some historic hundred mile trail and I'm picturing it like this and then you come in with some kind of heavy groove. And I'm thinking "No, this is downtown New York or something, this doesn't sound like a nice woodland scene." So I don't know. I think we're just such imaginative creatures aren't we, that we can create that story in our minds without words.

MR: Yeah. Titles are funny things. Sometimes it's hard to think of a title for an instrumental piece – at least that's happened to me, because it doesn't necessarily mean something or portray anything in particular. But I was curious about the title of your trio and so I did just a bit of looking into Satori. I'm going to be careful what I say because my knowledge about it is minimal. But this caught my eye, believe it or not, from the online *Encyclopedia Britannica* and it said, "Satori is said to be unexplainable, indescribable, and unintelligible by reason and logic."

JD: Nice.

MR: And I went wooh. It makes me think of music, especially the genre of music you play. Because sometimes there's not answers to these questions we're talking about.

JD: Absolutely. Yeah. I've not heard that definition before, and I can't remember the exact wording for the definition. When I first came across this word in a really great book called Free Play by Stephen Nachmanovich who is a sort of free improvising violinist, although I think he's classically trained, but he's written a wonderful book about creativity and spontaneity and what that means in our world. And in that he uses this term

"satori" which I think his definition is something like a moment of presence away from the clutter of the egoic mind, the thinking, analytic, rationalizing mind. And for me when I first put my trio together it was very much a choice to move away from the music I'd been playing prior to that which was very sort of changes-based I suppose, more in the American Songbook tradition, and I wanted to do something totally different I think, much more spacious, freeing, sort of let go of all of the structures that you get like time and harmony and a set number of bars/measures or the form, all of that stuff which I think is really important to work on and to be familiar with and comfortable in. And then see what happens if you let go of it all. And I do that to a different extent with different people and with different pieces which I'm writing. So that word really resonated with me in terms of that's what it is just to be present and not have any goal or direction necessarily that needs to happen. And something will happen.

MR: Would you describe the attraction to that as spiritual?

JD: Yeah, definitely. I think it goes alongside my sort of spiritual development that's been burgeoning over the past ten years or so I would say. And that is very much yes, trying to let go of, you know the egoic needs, the need to be in control of life. I heard this beautiful thing yesterday which was something about we have so little knowledge really about what consciousness is, what we're doing here, who are we, what's happening, what's in the universe. And yet we have a tiny, tiny, tiny amount of control over what we do and what that looks like but we grab it with both hands and we're so attached to the outcome of so many things – how we sound, what people think, what we look like, what we feel like on a day to day basis. And I think part of the musical development goes alongside that sort of spiritual development of seeing well what happens if I just let go of all of those needs, of all of that sense of control over my life. And it's very much a work in progress. Yeah. It's not somewhere I would say is a set piece.

MR: You've led me to a quote I wrote down from this conversation I had years ago with Maria Schneider, who I know you've mentioned in your information. But she said, "One of the problems with musicians is they get so caught up in making records and going on to the next project. But what feeds the music? Music is fed by a deep and rich life so I think it's really important to have other things in your life that you can do with equal love."

JD: Yup. Absolutely. Yeah. 100 percent I support that statement.

MR: So do you have interests outside of your projects, which are numerous and varied?

JD: Yes certainly. I'm an avid reader so I'm just always looking for – sometimes it's new information but also I'm an avid reader of novels. Oddly enough I was just thinking about this yesterday. Somebody asked me one of those impossible questions – it's an impossible, it's a ridiculous question, but he said, "Would you rather go blind or deaf?" you know that old sort of mental acrobatics to try to imagine yourself into either of those

things which is of course impossible when you have both of those faculties. But it was a real struggle because I thought reading for me is as important as music in some ways, to really lose myself in a world that somebody else has imagined and then is giving to me through the means of the page, where I'm – as I'm reading their world I'm creating my own world. And I think there is something so fundamentally important about that for me that I'm not sure I could be a composer or a musician if I couldn't experience that. I mean obviously people do and there are recordings in braille and all of that kind of thing, but as the question was being asked of me it just made me think about how important that is for me to sort of disappear into the other world. And I think part of my decision in my – when I turned 30 I sort of woke up one morning and decided that I really wanted to train as a psychotherapist. So I did a whole PhD in philosophy and psychotherapy. And when I got to the end of that, that was actually when I got my trio together. Because it opened up something for me that I was really passionate about. And then when I finished my doctorate I thought oh, I don't want to do that anymore so I went hell for leather straight back into music as my dad was saying, "Well what did you do that for? That was so much money and now you're not going to use it." But I think it's not about, it's not necessarily about deciding that something is going to look that way in four years or five years, you just do – you make a commitment, you do the journey, take the journey, and then you find out where you are. And I was fortunate enough, you know, financially, to be able to go back into music and to earn my living that way rather than have to be a psychotherapist when I sort of lost the passion for the practice. But I still have a passion for the philosophy. So I think that was a real interest. And yeah, all the other things I do: yoga and walking and – I live by the sea now so I swim in the sea every day, which is getting cold. And yeah, relationships. I find all of that stuff absolutely essential for my nourishment. Otherwise I'm a bit starving when I come to music. So I would say Maria is hitting the nail on the head.

MR: You did the opposite of what Phil Woods had said about young musicians. And his advice was well if you can be a doctor or a tenor player, be the doctor. And you went the other way.

JD: Yeah. But I'm really – it's got to be, obviously we live in a world where there are many limitations and constraints and we have to make it work in some way and it very much is about the possibilities that you have in life and also your dependents, who is relying on you, all of that stuff. But I think the question that – I was very fortunate enough to grow up with a mother whose – without explicitly stating it – letting me know that being – finding something passionate, finding something in your life that you're passionate about will bring you great joy. Maybe grief as well. This is not about a spot of bland happiness but it's – for me, particularly, it's about finding something that is going to be endlessly

rewarding and interesting. And for me that has to be something creative because I think that's where I want to go every day. What can I do that's sort of an expression of something or a connection with something rather than maybe being a doctor wouldn't be – who knows? It feels like it wouldn't have been as rewarding for me. But it is a little different in that sense.

MR: I want to ask you about at least one of your compositions that appears on your website, it's called "Cry." And it opens with, you know rubato. And I had two questions about it. First of all I think it's in A flat. And I wondered if you picked that because it allows – because on your tenor you would be in a key that allows for harmonics. It's helpful to be in that key to play those harmonics you were doing.

JD: Yes. I think that's in there. It's also the low B flat as the bottom note and I love that note. And also, just as I was coming up with the first section of the melody, and the high F on tenor is a really nice note, and then it goes up to altissimo B flat. And that just felt quite – it's quite a raw note, quite gritty, and it seemed to fit the atmosphere of that particular piece which is just really supposed to be very emotional, very raw and not sweet let's say. So I think that's why, yeah. And I wrote that, often I write at the piano, especially if it's got harmony. But that piece of music is just that sort of A flat pedal, which of course isn't the greatest for bass because it's not an open string. But sometimes you have to ignore that. And also it's Dave Whitford on bass and he's just incredible so he's happy to [inaudible].

MR: He's happy with A flats.

JD: Hell of a player. Yeah so it's more about the high notes, that top B flat. But I think that might be such a satisfying note because of the harmonic structure of the saxophone.

MR: There was a line in it that I got a flash – it reminded me of "Alabama" by John Coltrane.

JD: Well that's the inspiration.

MR: All right.

JD: Yeah. Because of the story as well, and his reason for writing "Alabama" which is absolutely heart-wrenching, heartbreakingly awful and through that comes this extraordinarily beautiful expression of one man, one man and his band, and that to me is also perhaps the value of really the way of being with the awful things in the world. And I talk about this a lot with people, especially because the world's in – there's so much craziness. And I think people can get very disheartened and depressed. And they can find themselves in a bit of an apoplectic state or what's the point of doing anything when the world leaders are all so monstrous. How on earth do we cope? What do we do? And I find that they sort of get in the mindset of just watching more news or sort of soaking up this terrible information. And my sense is that unless you do that consciously, and in some way use it for good, then it will suck you dry. It will absolutely suck your energy.

And so for me seeing something like – or listening to something like "Alabama" where John Coltrane is seeing this horrific crime, and then writing this extraordinarily beautiful piece of music and expressing all of whatever he was expressing within that. For me that's the inspiration. So what can I do with the feelings of struggle, darkness, despair. And if we as musicians, artists, whatever it is, if we can turn that darkness into something where people can be moved, can feel emotion, then that to me is just what a thing to do with one's life. That seems like a real honorable way to live. So yeah, I'm glad you said that, that you can hear that in that music, because that piece is very much inspired by not just the piece "Alabama" because maybe there's some of that in that, but it's more the ethos of taking some kind of struggle and turning it into an expression of hope, whatever it is.

MR: Beautifully said. Thank you. The other piece I was going to ask about, "Insomnia." I wonder if you have trouble sleeping. That's not my question.

JD: Sometimes the titles are literal. Yeah, that was very much – I go through periods of really quite terrible insomnia. And so sometimes I just get up and go and write something. So that was a 3 A.M. wake-up, this is not happening, I don't want to read a book, I don't want to meditate, I'm going to go and write that. And I quite like it, because it's a little bit snaky and dream-like and odd.

MR: Indeed. Fits the soprano really well. I noticed a subtle shift in the feel, almost like it was starting to swing, and I wondered if that was there, first of all, and was it like, does the song have a bridge?

JD: That's a really interesting question. It came out, when we recorded that, that was a live gig and it's interesting, Paul Clarvis is on that one, on drums, before James Maddren joined the band. And it's quite a different sound. And I think Paul is so heavily into the jazz tradition, he just brings that sense even if I've said specifically this is straight eighths, he will somehow morph. It's not a bad thing, I mean his feel is absolutely sublime and playing swing with him is just brilliant. And yeah, it wasn't in my mind that it would go in that direction I think.

MR: I enjoyed the difference hearing you live, and then you have like – I call it a promo video that you have there as well. And there's a part where you're just in the room by yourself playing the tenor and it's gorgeous.

JD: Oh thank you. I think, I mean the saxophone is a fun instrument. I often – I'm often envious of piano players because they can be everything. They can be rhythmic, harmonic, kind of you know, got it all going on in a way that I suppose a one line instrument – it's different let's say. But it is fun when you've got a reed that works and an acoustic that's really nice, then it's fun just to see what emerges when on one's own.

MR: What's the average venue that you try to book, and I'm wondering if you're required sometimes to explain what it is you're doing if a club owner asks you -- well it's not enough these days to say we play jazz. "Well what do you play? Trad jazz? Or do you do fusion?" Do you have an answer at the ready for that kind of situation?

JD: It's rough. It's so difficult that one. And I sort of say, depending on the project, but with Satori I say it's contemporary jazz. We do originals. And I might say sometimes in this – influenced by a certain person or it might seem that – if I'm trying to get a gig somewhere where they don't necessarily know me I might look on my website and see who's played that fits my genre I suppose, that is doing something similarly contemporary but not way out, kind of squeaky, honky, free jazz. And that's not playing trad jazz or you know maybe bebop, something like that, bebop, hard bop, that sense of, it would be good to just make sure that they're not expecting some Charlie Parker numbers and that we are going to be doing something perhaps more modern. But it is really difficult. And it's funny, what I've noticed is with the trio is because we play, there's a lot of free improvisation within it but there are still melodies and hooks and harmonic progressions, rhythmic things, all of that sort of stuff, some swing. It doesn't fit, say like Café Oto is perhaps the most famous venue in London for free jazz and it's really, you know, really left field. It's out there and you get to see some stuff that seems like just people are, you know that question is, "Is this music?" You know, that sort of just brought a load of kitchen utensils and they're throwing toy trains at them. That kind of thing. So I don't think it would work in there because it might be too jazz. But at the same time there are other venues who say it's too free or it's too experimental. So it's kind of difficult because I don't want to particularly categorize myself so much that I can't just do what I want to do. And in fact we did a gig the other day and I can't remember why, I was really moved to play "Isfahan." So we did "Isfahan" as a trio at the end of the night. It was great. It was so satisfying just to pop that in. And why not? You know Billy Strayhorn was an incredible composer. And it didn't feel any different from the rest of the gig you know, it didn't feel like oh we've run out of tunes, let's play a 12-bar blues.

MR: Do you ever do that? Play a 12-bar blues?

JD: Yeah I love playing a 12-bar blues.

MR: Yeah me too.

JD: Yeah. What's not to love?

MR: I'm glad you said that. You know compared to other free jazz I've heard, and I'm more into Cannonball Adderley and soul jazz personally, but your music felt less demonstrative and more inviting I think than a lot of, I'll still use the term free jazz. It's an observation, not really a question. Perhaps, I've seen some comments on your playing

and they used – the critics used the term "melodic" and "melodies." And what makes a good melody for you?

JD: Ooo. That's a great question. I suppose something singable, and in fact a lot of the time when I'm writing I'm singing the line rather than necessarily playing it on the piano or the saxophone. Or I might start there and then I think oh well what comes next. Or sing what I've just written and then see what voice comes up then. So I suppose that's part of it. Being singable. But it's so intangible, some of this stuff, the quest for the perfect melody. I will answer that from a spiritual perspective actually, because I love this concept that I also discovered from the writer Elizabeth Gilbert, who I think is a great speaker as well. She's very articulate and she's got some very interesting ideas about creativity. And one of those, I don't think it's her idea but she adheres to this idea, that ideas are present in the universe. We can't see them because they're in a different dimension, but they're constantly inviting us to interact with them and come and play. And sometimes when we're open enough we get to have a relationship with that idea and we catch it and we write it down. And I just thought, oh that's so interesting and so different from this idea that everything comes from the individual. You have to come up with everything and it's all on your shoulders and the responsibility comes from you, so if it's not very good, you're not very good. It's very liberating in that sense. But I really like it, just when I'm writing, especially when it's the more melodic pieces, but the idea is out there, and I've just got to keep listening until I can harness it. And that for me is where the most satisfying writing becomes, because it's almost like it's inevitable, because the melody already exists and I've just written it down, even though it doesn't exist because obviously that would be plagiarism. So it's coming from me but it's not, it's sort of in there somewhere, in a different dimension, I'm trying to find it. And it's quite good. Many people would just be – many people might be at this moment thinking what is she all about, this mad English woman. But you know --

MR: Well Karl Berger, who passed away a couple of years ago, but he had the Creative Music Workshop north of New York. And he said, "Music is being thought of as something that entertains us and that can be used for other certain purposes. But it's a world. You go there. Everybody can go there whether you play or not. You're in the world of spontaneity and you're no longer in the thinking world. You leave the thinking world behind.

JD: Mmm.

MR: What do you think about when you play?

JD: Well the best night is where I'm not thinking. And that goes back to that idea of Satori, the concept of presence. And that's I think where I find the most freedom and the most – oh yeah that sense of just being right here right now. It sort of transcends all of the other

stuff that one has to think about. And I'm a very undisciplined and not very good meditator. I don't like sitting still and I get very impatient and I know many people probably are going yes, that is what meditation is. But to me I think that that sense of being in a meditative state comes when I'm really in the music either listening or performing. And it's so satisfying. However, it's not always that kind of slow state, as I think some people call it. Sometimes I am thinking and that can be quite distracting. For example, "Ooh I want this to be good." And that's a terrible thing to think because there's so much pressure on you, and then you're not responding. You're thinking what can I do here that would sound good, rather than what can I do here that would sound like the right thing to do here. And maybe it's nothing. Maybe it's silence or maybe it's one note or maybe it's just the root of whatever else is happening. You're not just adding to the whole soundscape rather than going ooh, what impressive things do I know on the saxophone. That's the worst possible thing that I could be thinking. But it's hard to just let that go. That's part of the spiritual and musical development isn't it? Letting go of the need to do anything except see what the right thing is to do in the moment.

MR: Yeah, or to be the director of what's going on here. I had this impression as you were talking like if you're thinking too hard it's actually like you're trying to shape this music by yourself and maybe you're not paying close attention to your bandmates.

JD: Yeah. Exactly. Yeah. And especially with this kind of music. There is more open and free and more about the sort of collective improvisation. I think there's a real sense of the more humble you can be and the less egotistic, the better the overall experience will be for the listener. And it's remembering that sense of why we're doing what we're doing and what we might give rather than what can I show off about. I'm being facetious but I think having that sense of humility can be a really great starting point.

MR: If you talk to current jazz musicians here in the States about the state of jazz, it's usually not an uplifting conversation. Over here we have -- academia keeps the music alive I think. That's where it mostly lives. Or in the wealthy institutions. But club-wise it's not a – in comparison to what – where are the good old days, I'm not sure which days they were. But I'm wondering about how hard is it to make a living as a jazz musician in England?

JD: Yeah. It's one of those questions that again it depends on the mood of the person speaking probably. I think it is hard. I think it has got harder. There is a sense sometimes of no one's got any money and there are so many bands trying to get the same gigs and every year there are more bands. Most of them are fantastic. And there are fewer pubs and the pubs that there are lose their funding, and the travel around the U.K. is difficult, everything is expensive, traffic is horrendous, etcetera, etcetera. And so there is a reality to all of that. But I'm a big proponent of there is some positive, not in a bland, facile way,

but a sense of how can I make the current world work for me. Because I think it's always good to bear in mind that yes there are things that are more challenging, more difficult, and potentially terrible. But there are also things that have become better for a lot of people. And I think it's important for me to remember that and feel that I am still living this incredibly creative, spontaneous, free life, which is extraordinary to have that and to be able to really do what I want on a daily basis. I mean I have made the decision I am – I don't have a husband or children or animals or anything like that. So I have curated my life to be one in which I can have enough freedom and not have to worry too much about the difficulty of getting gigs. So there'll always be something that I can do to make money. So for me it's not so much about the financial aspect as just where would I like to play and it's a struggle trying to get gigs at places like Ron Scott's where I love playing Ronnie Scott's and it's very high profile and it's a great venue, and incredibly hard to get a gig there. Because they look, as many venues do now, they look at your Instagram profile to see how many likes you have and how many followers. Things like that. Where you don't really have a sense of control over that unless you are somebody that does social media on a daily basis and make it part of your job. Fair enough to the people who are doing that. I don't really want to because of lots of reasons. I don't really want to. But it does make it more difficult because they will literally say, "Well you can't guarantee an audience." And I'll say, "Well no, I can't." So I don't know what needs to happen to sort of make things slightly easier. I think there are certain musicians for whom it is easier because they've got a higher profile, maybe they're more – they've got a long history of having an audience. And then there was some newcomers who become quite high profile quite quickly. And then there's the majority, the 98 percent of us in the middle who are going hmm, must I do another Instagram post if I want to get a gig at Ronnie Scott's? Again I'm being slightly facetious but I'd say it is difficult. I'd say everyone would answer that question slightly differently, that it's hard to know really. But I try and keep on keeping on, because I love what I do.

MR: Well said again. A little shift here. In watching your videos, especially the live ones, I saw music stands some of the time with your drummer and bass player, and I really wanted to see what your scores look like. Do you – how much do you write out, and do you use non- – what I'll describe as creative notation other than notes?

JD: Ooo. Yeah. Probably. I do write things down most of the time. Sometimes that will be a scribble on a piece of paper and it will sort of say, I use the word "ish" quite a lot. So the B minor-ish, as in eh, we might have a sort of tonic area of B and let me see what happens. And I play with people who are so able to interpret anything. But it goes in its own direction no matter how much or how little I write. And then some of the more involved pieces will probably be a more traditional score where everyone has a sense of

what they're doing. But I hope, even within those things there's enough space for us to get away from the page and do our own thing and then come back to it. Yeah.

MR: Do you hate writing piano parts if they're anything more than chords?

JD: No, no I love it. In fact I write --

MR: No kidding.

JD: Yeah, I love it. I write quite a lot of them, piano parts, stuff that I compose at the piano. And sometimes if I can be really specific about what I want because that's how I've written it. So I rather than write the chord sequence I'll actually write the voicing that I want or the pattern that I want the piano player to play. And that can be really specific. Yeah.

MR: And are you still a pen and paper person? Pencil and paper or are you in Finale etcetera?

JD: Pen and paper to start and then I will put it on Sibelius, for people to read, which actually I quite enjoy. I like making it all neat and then it's there in case I want to do any edits the next time. And I have a friend who is only pen and paper and it's always a challenge because his naturals look like sharps. I told him.

MR: That's a great way to slow down a recording session.

JD: Exactly.

MR: Is that a sharp or is that a natural?

JD: Yeah.

MR: What's up for you next? Do you find that you need to shift from project to project depending on the availability of the people you play with?

JD: Yeah. Actually up next is something I'm – it is a collaboration but it's under the harp player's name. There's a harpist called Maria-Christina Harper oddly enough. She's a Greek musician. And we started playing together about four years ago and we have a trio with me on saxophone and a drummer. And the drummer is in a couple of bands that are on tour a lot. So actually the next project I'm doing is we have an album release at the end of this month so we're doing a tour, just around the U.K. for now, although we did just play in Greece which was lovely. And that, we're sort of trying to line up all the dates within October and November because the drummer then goes off on tour for about six months after that. So with that project it's very much, that is dependent on people's availability. But actually with Satori I often book, I often book dates hoping that everyone is free. But often James Maddren isn't, he's away a lot of the time. And I have a couple of wonderful set drummers and so it still sounds like a band and that music is kind of free and spontaneous enough for it to be someone can sort of step in and do their thing rather than need to sound like James Maddren which wouldn't be really what I want somebody to feel like they have to do.

MR: Yeah, and as you said, you mentioned the one drummer that was playing on "Insomnia" I guess and that they brought something to the table that someone else might not have.

JD: Yeah. Absolutely. And I think that's what I'm looking for really in band members is somebody that can complement what I've written but also really be able to do their own thing and interpret the music, so they'll come up with ideas that I never would have considered. And then it will go in a different direction and it very much feels like a band rather than I'm the sole composer of this piece of music and anyone can come in and just play it note for note. But that's something that jazz musicians --

MR: A couple of things to wrap up with. I know it's hard to pinpoint one thing ever, you know one thing. But is there one recording that you can point to that you heard perhaps in your teen years that just like opened your ears up and provided some inspiration to you?

JD: Yes. I can very much pinpoint the album, because funnily enough I was not into jazz at all. I don't think I ever heard any jazz as a teenager, or if I did I would have thought what is all this nonsense. You know I was listening to pretty much '80s pop music and '90s pop music. And I was into – maybe I won't say that, it's slightly embarrassing. But yes, some low profile popular music let's say all through my teenage years. And I went to Guildhall, which is one of the music colleges in London, when I was 18, as a classical saxophonist and not really having thought about wanting to do music. I'd actually wanted to go into acting and then my best friend who is an opera singer was going to Guildhall and I just sort of followed her. I just had no sense of autonomy really when I was 17, 18 – I just kind of did what other people suggested which surprises me looking back. Anyway I got there and I was amazed that I got in actually because I was an incredibly average saxophonist. I just played a little bit. I think I passed like grade 8 or something quite recently, hadn't really developed any sense of theory or aural or harmony skills, so really knew not very much at all. But I did get in and when I got there and they really showed me what classical alto actually sounds like I thought oh, I don't really like this. Oh no, sort of oh what am I going to do, do I need to think about this. And in the halls of residence that I was living in in my first year someone had "A Love Supreme," John Coltrane and I heard that and I thought well that sounds like freedom to me. That sounds like some kind of way of expressing life that would be affirming and useful and incredible. And then so I switched to the jazz course when I was 18 or 19 I should say.

MR: Terrific.

JD: That would be the album.

MR: We all have our albums, that's for sure.

JD: Mmm hmm.

MR: Okay last question, this is really deep. Did your dad ever come out to see you and what did he think?

JD: I've got two answers for you. The first one is not really. My dad doesn't like – well he likes a bit of trad jazz and he doesn't like what I do even though he values the fact that I do something which requires a certain amount of skill and discipline. And I think there's also an element of jealousy or slight envy because I think he really wanted to be a rock & roll pianist and didn't, he didn't do that. So I think he's slightly frustrated as a performer himself. So no, he doesn't come to see me play. But the other part of the answer is that my mum absolutely comes to everything. She's a huge supporter and fan. And we did a gig together the other day. She's a writer and a poet and so the band I'm recording with today actually, we did some free improvisation underneath and around a short story that she was reading and it was magical, really wonderful.

MR: I'm happy to hear that. And before I go I wanted to say, you were talking about '80s pop music, well over here we were absolutely nuts about Nik Kershaw.

JD: Oh yeah.

MR: He had a – you know he was just great. Anyway this has been a really wonderful conversation. I'm very pleased we were able to do it, and I wish you all the best in the future.

JD: Thank you so much, it was really wonderful to talk with you.

MR: All right. I'll pause here and we'll say our good-byes. Thanks a lot, Josephine.

JD: Thank you.